VARSITY PATH

AGILE TEAM CHARTER

1. Team Purpose & Vision

Why do we exist as a team?

Team mission: To develop and improve VarsityPath, an AI-supported education and university-readiness platform for Grade 11–12 learners in the Western Cape. The platform brings academic results, learning insights, study goals, programme exploration and application tracking into one learner-centred journey. It aims to help learners understand their current academic position and make better-informed decisions about their next steps, while protecting their personal information and being transparent about the limits of AI and admission estimates.

Success definition: The following are proposed project success measures for the team to confirm and adapt; they are targets, not results already achieved.

- **Learner usability:** In user testing, at least 80% of participating learners should complete key tasks entering or reviewing results, finding a learning gap, creating a study task, and locating programme information without assistance.
- **Data accuracy and trust:** AI-extracted result rows must remain editable and must never be saved until the learner reviews and confirms them. Unreadable files should produce a clear error or review state rather than invented marks.
- **Eligibility reliability**: Programme recommendations must use institution- and programme-specific rules, explain the criteria used, and disclose uncertainty when a requirement cannot be evaluated reliably.
- **Workflow completion**: Test users should be able to move from results review to Improve insights, study planning, Apply programme exploration and Application Tracker updates.
- **Privacy and quality**: Testing should confirm that a learner can access only their own private records, that empty accounts show no fabricated data, and that core workflows pass before a release.

Product / service: VarsityPath is a web-based platform built around account-based learner access. Its main functions include manual entry and AI-assisted extraction of school results; an Improve module for strengths and knowledge gaps; goals and a Study Planner; an Apply module and university explorer for UCT, Stellenbosch University, UWC and CPUT; institution-aware eligibility checks; an Application Tracker; and an AI assistant that explains and guides without replacing official university decisions or processes.

2. Team Members & Roles

Who is on the team and how do we contribute?

Team member	Role	Key responsibilities
Bambanani Liwani	Agile Lead / Project Coordinator	Facilitate planning, daily check-ins, sprint reviews and retrospectives; track blockers and keep the team aligned with the project goals.
Ratiloe Mbonani	Frontend Developer / UX Designer	Build and refine the React/TypeScript interface; make results, Improve, Apply, Study Planner and Tracker workflows understandable and accessible.
Siyamthanda Mafuta	Backend / Data and Security Developer	Maintain authentication, Firestore data paths and access rules; protect learner records and AI-service secrets; validate persistence and data separation.
Nelisiwe Makhabane	Testing / Documentation Lead	Run workflow, security, data-integrity and error-state tests; record issues; keep technical and user documentation current.

3. Ways of Working

The team works collaboratively and keeps work visible. Tasks should be prioritised according to learner value, privacy, correctness and project deadlines. Team members communicate progress, raise blockers early and review changes before treating them as complete.

3.1 Agile Framework

- Kanban.

3.2 Ceremonies

Ceremony	Frequency	Purpose
Daily stand-up	Daily, 10–15 minutes	Share what was completed, what comes next, and any blockers affecting progress.
Sprint planning	At the start of each sprint	Choose achievable tasks based on priority, capacity and acceptance criteria.
Sprint review	During each sprint	Demonstrate completed features and gather feedback on learner workflows and correctness.
Retrospective	At the end of each sprint	Discuss what worked, what did not, and one or two improvements for the next sprint.
Backlog refinement	Once per sprint, as needed	Clarify requirements and break larger features into testable tasks.

4. Working Agreements

Rules we agree to follow as a team:

- Arrive prepared and respect agreed meeting times and timeboxes.
- Keep the task board and project documentation updated so progress is visible.

- Give respectful, constructive feedback and explain the reason for suggested changes.
- Raise blockers, risks and uncertainty early instead of waiting until a deadline.
- Do not use fabricated learner marks, fake dashboard metrics or sample records as if they were real user data.
- Review AI-extracted results with the learner before saving; do not invent unreadable marks.
- Keep Improve results separate from Apply results because they serve different purposes.
- Treat learner marks, goals, tasks and application details as private data.
- Use official institutional sources for programme requirements and deadlines and record verification dates where available.
- Test changes and update relevant documentation before marking a task complete.

5. Communication

How and when we communicate

Primary channels: Use the team's agreed messaging platform for quick coordination and a formal channel such as email or Microsoft Teams for decisions, meeting notes and documentation. Use the shared task board and repository to track work and technical changes. The specific tools must be confirmed by the team.

Response-time expectations:

core hours: 09:00 – 16:00

Urgent: Schedule in-person meeting

Remote / hybrid norms: Teams meeting or voice calls.

6. Decision Making

How decisions are made

- Seeking team consensus for design, workflow and implementation choices where practical.
- The Product Owner / project lead prioritises product scope after considering learner needs, feasibility, evidence and team input.
- Technical decisions should be discussed with the relevant developers and documented, especially when they affect data security, scoring, eligibility or persistence.
- If the team cannot reach agreement, compare options against user value, privacy, reliability, accessibility, time and available resources; the designated lead makes the final project decision after hearing the team.

7. Definition of Done (DoD)

Work is considered done when the applicable criteria below have been met:

- The user problem and acceptance criteria are understood.
- The interface or design has been reviewed for clarity, consistency and accessibility.
- The feature works with authenticated user data and persists correctly where persistence is required.

- No fake results, scores, deadlines, application statuses or programme requirements are presented as genuine.
- AI-extracted marks remain provisional until reviewed and confirmed by the learner.
- Improve and Apply data remain separate and the seven-unique-subject discovery gate is tested.
- Eligibility logic is checked against the applicable institution/programme rule set; relevant criteria and limitations are explained.
- Private learner records are protected by authentication and access controls; one learner cannot access another learner's records.
- Relevant success, empty, loading, validation and error states are handled clearly.
- The features have been tested, defects are recorded, and critical issues are resolved or explicitly documented.
- Technical and user documentation is updated, and the change is reviewed by the responsible team member or Product Owner.
- The agreed delivery environment has been checked before release.

8. Core Values & Behaviours

How we treat each other

- Respect
- Transparency
- Accountability
- Trust and privacy
- Accuracy
- Collaboration
- Learning mindset
- Accessibility and inclusion

9. Risks & Constraints

What could impact our success?

Known risks:

- AI may misread subject names, marks or dates from uploaded results; incorrect extraction could mislead learners if it is not reviewed.
- University admission rules, programme availability, score methods and deadlines can change by institution, programme and intake.
- A single universal APS formula could produce misleading eligibility information because requirements differ across institutions and programmes.
- Learner academic and application data could be exposed if authentication, Firestore security rules or access checks are misconfigured.
- AI services, network connectivity or database persistence may fail, interrupting extraction, assistance or saving.

- Learners may misunderstand a VarsityPath reference number or tracker status as an official university student number or proof of institutional submission.
- Duplicate tasks, application records or inconsistent data between modules could reduce trust and usability.

Dependencies:

- Firebase Authentication and Cloud Firestore, including correctly configured per-user data paths and security rules.
- The configured Gemini / approved AI service for extraction and assistant features, with secrets protected outside frontend code.
- Verified, up-to-date official university programme and admission requirement sources for UCT, Stellenbosch University, UWC and CPUT.
- A working React and TypeScript frontend, data persistence, and a stable development/testing environment.
- Learner review and confirmation of extracted results, plus clear user feedback for failures and missing information.

Constraints (time, budget, tools, skills):

Time: Project deadline is fixed.

No budget for paid APIs, cloud hosting costs or testing devices.

Teams have different skills others do not know a lot about coding.

10. Review & Improvement

Keeping the charter alive

- Review the charter at each sprint retrospective and whenever the team, scope, responsibilities or working arrangements change.
- Update success measures when usability testing and implementation evidence provide a more realistic baseline.
- Review programme-rule verification, data protection, AI failure handling and user feedback as part of ongoing quality improvement.

Charter review frequency: At each sprint retrospective; additionally, before a major release.

Last updated: 3 September 2026

11. Team Commitment

Our agreement to this charter

By working on VarsityPath, we commit to the purpose, working agreements, values and quality expectations described above. We will collaborate to build a useful and trustworthy learner-readiness platform, protect learner information, use verified requirements, and communicate honestly about what VarsityPath can and cannot do.

Name	Role	Signature / agreement
Bambanani Liwani	Agile Lead / Project Coordinator	B Liwani
Ratiloe Mbonani	Frontend Developer / UX Designer	R Mbonani
Siyamthanda Mafuta	Backend / Data and Security Developer	S Mafuta
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